

Nathan Madsen

Carole Paul

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Art Analysis 2 – Prompt II

The onset of the Protestant Reformation, initiated by Martin Luther in 1517, fundamentally altered the relationship between religion and visual culture in both Northern and Southern Europe. As the movement spread, theologians debated the proper role of art, questioning whether images could serve a legitimate devotional or educational purpose, or if they inherently encouraged idolatry. For artists working in the mid-to-late sixteenth century, this shifting religious landscape required a careful reevaluation of how to approach scriptural subject matter without violating new theological boundaries. In his 1568 painting *Parable of the Blind*, Pieter Bruegel the Elder ingeniously conforms to protestant standard for religious imagery; by deliberately excluding divine figures to avoid idolatry, focusing on the biblical narrative, and utilizing a stark descending composition, Bruegel fulfills a Protestant vision of art as a purely didactic moral tool, rather than an object of devotional worship.

At the time of the painting's creation, the Protestant Reformation, sparked by the 1517 posting of the 95 theses in Wittenberg, was well underway. With this came new expectations for the role that art should play in society, specifically in religious settings, upending the previous Catholic thinking on the usage of art which was the source of much of art in previous centuries. Protestants admitted a variety of different opinions on the proper role of art. Some thinkers like Andreas Karlstadt, a prominent theologian and professor at the University of Wittenberg, rejected its role wholly, stating "That we have images in churches and houses of God is wrong

and contrary to the first commandment... Thou shalt have no other gods before me. Thou shalt not make unto thee any graven image”.¹ It was feared that these depictions of holy figures would promote idolatry in the sense that they may inspire worship of themselves rather than the figures they were meant to represent. To some protestant theologians this was not an affliction of a viewer improperly or uneducatedly engaging with the art but rather a fundamental issue with humans themselves, built into Original Sin since the fall of Adam and Eve. John Calvin, founder of the Calvinist church, described every man as “master craftsman of idols” and said that “humans cannot resist idolizing” art². This thinking left little room for any kind of religious art. However, Bruegel perfectly addresses these fears, by deliberately not painting the Virgin Mary, saints, or divine figures, he removes any temptation to treat the painting as a Catholic idol. Instead of creating a physical image of the immaterial God, as Calvin described humans were so inherently tempted to do, Bruegel paints everyday, flawed humans and completely bypasses this human trap.

Some protestants took this line of thinking so far as to believing that art should not only be removed from churches, but destroyed. According to Smith “Zurich suffered almost total destruction of its religious art... Throughout Germany statues were hacked apart or burned”³. However, not all protestants rejected art as harshly as Karlstadt and Calvin did, in fact some were vehemently against this view and the destruction of art that went with it. Martin Luther, the monk who originally posted the 95 theses and started the protestant reformation, even went as far as to call Karlstadt a “false prophet”⁴. Martin Luther believed that art played an important, but limited, role in religion, namely as didactic and pedagogical tools for a mostly illiterate

¹ Jeffery Chipps Smith, *German Sculpture of the Later Renaissance* (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 1994), 31

² Smith, *German Sculpture*, 34

³ Smith, *German Sculpture*, 35

⁴ Smith, *German Sculpture*, 33

congregation. Smith writes that Luther “came to appreciate the positive didactic role that art could play” specifically art that “illustrated appropriate themes based on the bible”⁵. It is exactly these kinds of appropriate themes that Pieter Bruegel chooses to represent in *Parable of the Blind*. To Luther Bruegel was not just avoiding the bad, idolatrous, Catholic style of art, but engaging in the creation of good art that could clearly convey a biblical narrative.

Bruegel uses the compositional structure of his piece to a clearly didactic end in depicting a stylized version of the parable of the blind from the Bible. The painting consists of a line of six men, each with a unique vision impairment, walking to the left across the canvas, each guiding the man after him in states descending from upright to entirely supine in some sort of ditch. Each figure holds a walking stick, yet only the man in the back of the line is using it to make contact with the ground in front of him. Bruegel uses specific stylistic choices to ensure this scene is read as a moral lesson rather than a historical or divine event. Despite the scriptural origin of the narrative, the men wear sixteenth-century contemporary garb. This visual clue signals to viewers that the folly of spiritual blindness is not confined to the past; it was as much a threat in 1568 as it was during the time of Christ. Consequently, this shifts the focus away from the mere figures and towards an inward contemplation, if the figures are contemporary then the contemporary viewer too must also be subject to the risk of being led by the blind.

Between the fourth and fifth man there is a prominent church building sitting quietly in the background, untouched by the falling men. This church is also painted to reflect a contemporary architectural style, once again drawing the viewer into the scene as a familiar location and inviting them to reflect on how this parable may be symbolic of their own life. The stability of the stone structure and the erectness of the bell tower is an obvious juxtaposition to the tumbling men. Through this contrast, Bruegel visually echoes Ulrich Zwingli’s theological

⁵ Smith, *German Sculpture*, 33

assertion that “Christ alone was given us a model for living, and not the saints; for the head must lead us, and not the members”⁶. Perhaps the men represent the “outward stupidity” of spiritual blindness, that Zwingli argued comes from images, following false human models instead of the ultimate head, Christ. The church in the background stands as a symbol of the true repository of God’s word, which the blind men literally turn their back on as they stumble into the ditch. Furthermore, Bruegel depicts the church as intentionally small and unadorned, deliberately stripping it of what Martin Luther denounced as the deceptive “glitter” of human inventions and ornaments. By presenting a plain sanctuary, Bruegel draws the viewer’s focus away from the material distractions and redirects it toward the Words of God, which it represents, transforming the background architecture into a visual manifestation of the Protestant doctrine of *Sola Scriptura*.

Ultimately, Pieter Bruegel the Elder’s *Parable of the Blind* masterfully navigates the volatile spiritual landscape of the sixteenth century. Rather than succumbing to the iconoclasm of Karlstadt or Calvin, which threatened to leave Europe entirely devoid of visual culture, as it nearly did in Zurich, Bruegel successfully charts a moderate path that directly aligns with the didactic criteria put forth by Martin Luther and others. By filtering a biblical narrative through a contemporary, and even secularized lens, the painting actively shifts the viewer’s focus away from the late-medieval tradition of image veneration and toward rigorous internal moral self-examination. Every element of the work, from the sweeping, downward diagonal of the tumbling men to the unadorned simplicity of the background church, serves to reject the material “glitter” of Catholic tradition in favor of spiritual vigilance. In doing so, Bruegel proves that art did not need to be destroyed to be purified. Instead, *Parable of the Blind* stands as a testament to

⁶ Smith, *German Sculpture*, 33

how Northern Renaissance art successfully reinvented itself and transformed from an object of idolatrous worship and into a manifestation of the Word alone.